

Using energy meters to aid in research

A Brief Guide to using energy meters to support individuals with additional needs during the research process

ENERGY METERS

Energy meters can prepare people with additional needs to express their opinions on important subjects. This system uses energy levels to allow people to share how they feel about a topic (things we do at school, in this example). Open-ended questions guide the discussion, and individuals choose which energy level they associate with the topic item.

HOW DO WE DO IT? STEP ONE;

Think about your topic. It should be something you can ask open-ended questions about, like "How do you feel about [thing we do at school]?" instead of just "Do you like school?"

STEP TWO;

Set up the energy meter. there should be;

- The energy meter
- Symbols related to the topic (i.e., things we do at school, so reading, maths, etc)
- Space next to the energy meter to enable the individual to put the symbols down

STEP THREE;

Explain the activity to the student by, for example, talking through a narrative for anxiety. (See our other guidance on narratives for anxiety)

STEP FOUR;

Gain consent from the student you are working with (see our guidance on consent)

THINGS TO CONSIDER

- Have some sticky notes on hand to create new symbols as the conversation goes along.
- Get an understanding of the individuals level of symbolic representation... would they be better with photographs?
- If using symbols, consider which symbol set will be most recognisable for them (e.g. Widgit vs PCS)
- Build trust and connection with the individual before having these conversations
- Work closely with the individual and those who know them best to ensure that the questions/format respect their communication style



Reading

Symbols and words used here are simply a universal example, tailor your energy meter to your participants interests, such as pokemon, or Taylor Swift songs. See tools on the "[Autism Level UP!](#)" website for further examples.

My Energy in this activity

Full of Energy!!!!

Buzzing!

Focussed

Chilled Out

Sleepy

No Energy

Do I like it?



Like



Not sure



Dislike

Energy Meter © Laurent & Fede, 2019 all rights reserved

Symbols © PCS is a trademark of Tobii Dynavox LLC. All rights reserved. Used with permission.

STEP FIVE;

Introduce the conversation, e.g. Let's talk about things we do at school. I will show you some things you do at school, and I'd like you to place it next to how much energy you have during that activity

Hand the individual each symbol and ask "how much energy do you have in?..."

STEP SIX;

When the symbol has been placed, read it back to the individual (i.e., reading makes you feel sleepy?) and give them the opportunity to make any changes.

STEP SEVEN;

If appropriate with the student you are working with, follow up with each symbol (i.e., do you like or dislike that you feel that way? why does reading make you feel tired?)